

Grape Profiles

20 Essential Varieties — Origin · Aroma · Palate · Soil · Pairings

A comprehensive visual reference for every major grape variety — from the famous to the fascinating. Each profile includes the grape's origin story, a visual structure radar, primary and tertiary aroma profiles, key growing regions around the world, palate description, soil affinities, and food pairing guide.

Red Grapes

Pinot Noir

Cabernet Sauvignon

Merlot

Syrah / Shiraz

Grenache

Tempranillo

Sangiovese

Nebbiolo

Malbec

Cabernet Franc

Mourvèdre

Gamay

White Grapes

Chardonnay

Sauvignon Blanc

Riesling

Viognier

Chenin Blanc

Albariño

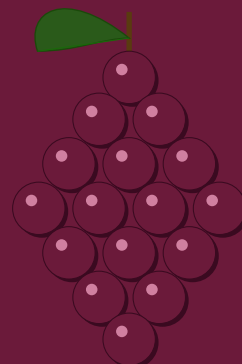
Grüner Veltliner

PINOT NOIR

■ ■ Burgundy, France · Ancient — one of the oldest documented varieties

Also known as: Spätburgunder (Germany) · Pinot Nero (Italy) · Pinot Noir (Oregon)

The world's most discussed, most obsessed-over red grape. Thin-skinned and fragile, Pinot Noir is transparent to its terroir in a way no other variety matches. The same clone grown a hundred metres apart in Burgundy produces wines that taste worlds apart.



Young

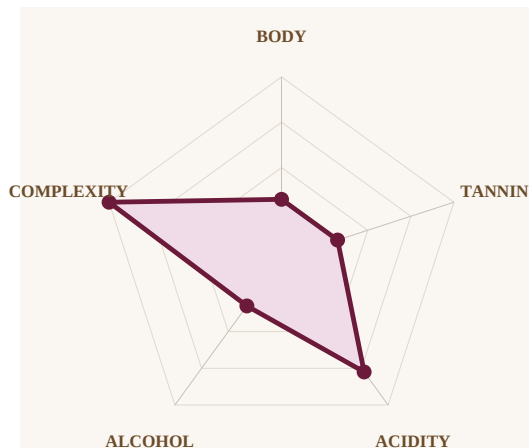
Ruby

Garnet

Aged Garnet

Mature

Brick



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Tannin	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Complexity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Burgundy, France
Ripens	Early — first of the reds
Skin	Very thin — fragile
Yields	Low — quality-focused
Aging	3–35+ years (Grand Cru)
Peak	8–20 years (village wine)
Serve	14–16 °C — slightly cool
Decant	30–45 min (older wines)

ORIGIN & STORY

Pinot Noir is one of the oldest cultivated grape varieties — documented in Burgundy since at least the 14th century, and almost certainly grown there long before. Its name comes from the French words for pine (pinot — referring to the tight, pine-cone shaped cluster) and black (noir). DNA profiling has confirmed it is a parent of Chardonnay, Pinot Gris, and Pinot Blanc — all natural mutations of the same ancient variety.

It was famously banned from Burgundy's neighbour Beaujolais in 1395 by Philip the Bold, Duke of Burgundy, who preferred it kept within his finest vineyards. Unlike Cabernet Sauvignon, which can produce excellent wine in many climates, Pinot Noir is extraordinarily site-sensitive — it demands cool climates, specific soils, and meticulous viticulture. More than any other grape, it is a direct expression of the exact piece of earth it grew on. The wines of Gevrey-Chambertin and Chambolle-Musigny taste worlds apart despite being adjacent villages — this is the magic and the obsession of Pinot Noir.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Côte de Nuits	Burgundy, France	The spiritual home — Gevrey, Chambolle, Vosne-Romanée
■ ■ Côte de Beaune	Burgundy, France	Volnay, Pommard — more feminine and approachable
■ ■ Willamette Valley	Oregon, USA	Most Burgundian New World expression — elegant, earthy

■■ Russian River Valley	Sonoma, USA	Silky, complex — benchmark California Pinot
■■ Sta. Rita Hills	Santa Barbara, USA	Diatomaceous earth · cool coastal fog · bold, structured, precise
■■ Central Otago	New Zealand	World's southernmost — concentrated cherry, structured
■■ Yarra Valley	Victoria, Australia	Cool, elegant, Burgundy-inspired style
■■ Baden / Pfalz	Germany	Spätburgunder — increasingly serious, earthy, delicate
■■ Casablanca Valley	Chile	Cool coastal — bright red fruit, growing reputation

PINOT NOIR

Continued — Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



RED FRUIT

Red Cherry

Raspberry

Strawberry

Cranberry

Red Plum

Pomegranate



FLORAL

Dried Rose

Violet

Lilac

Hibiscus

SECONDARY — from winemaking:



OAK / LEES

Subtle Vanilla

Cedar

Bread Dough

Light Toast

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



EARTH

Forest Floor

Mushroom

Wet Leaves

Truffle

Damp Earth

Game



COMPLEX

Dried Rose (aged)

Smoke

Leather

Tobacco

Dark Spice

PALATE PROFILE

Pinot Noir's defining palate characteristic is the paradox at its heart: deceptively light in colour and body, yet delivering extraordinary complexity. The tannins are low and silky — nothing like the firm grip of Cabernet. The acidity is high and energetic, creating a wine that feels alive and vibrant on the palate.

In youth: bright red fruit (cherry, raspberry), floral notes, fresh acidity. At 5–10 years: the fruit deepens, earthy notes emerge, the texture becomes increasingly silky. At 15–25 years in a Grand Cru: truffle, forest floor, dried rose, remarkable complexity — one of the most profound and beautiful drinking experiences in wine.

Key flavour descriptors:

Red Cherry

Raspberry

Pomegranate

Cranberry

Strawberry Jam

Forest Floor

Mushroom

Truffle (aged)

Wet Earth

Dried Leaves

Dried Rose

Violet

Light Cedar

Subtle Vanilla

Tobacco (aged)

SOIL AFFINITY

Limestone

Clay-Limestone

Kimmeridgian Clay

Granite

Schist / Slate

Sandy Loam (Oregon)

Volcanic Basalt

Marlstone

PAIRS WELL WITH

Roast Duck

Salmon

Chicken

Mushroom Risotto

Venison

Veal

Charcuterie

Brie & Camembert

Wild Mushrooms

Coq au Vin

Truffle Pasta

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

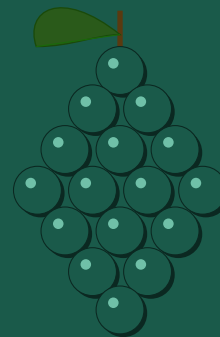
Serving Temp	14–16 °C (57–61 °F) — slightly cooler than most reds. Cold suppresses the fruit; too warm and the alcohol dominates.
Decanting	30–45 minutes for wines under 10 years · 1–2 hours for older bottles · Very old Burgundy: decant for 15 min only
Glass	Large Burgundy bowl — amplifies the delicate aromas. The wide bowl allows oxygen contact and collects volatile aromatics.
When to Open	Village wines: 3–8 years · Premier Cru: 6–15 years · Grand Cru: 10–25+ years. Patience is always rewarded.
Storage	55–58 °F (13–14 °C) · 70–75% humidity · on its side · away from vibration and light
Famous Producers	DRC (Romanée-Conti) · Leroy · Rousseau · Dujac · Roumier · Drouhin (Oregon) · Eyrie (Oregon) · Felton Road (NZ)

ALBARIÑO

■ ■ Origin: Rías Baixas, Galicia, Spain

Synonyms: Alvarinho (Vinho Verde, Portugal)

Spain's great seafood white · Saline · Atlantic · Born for the ocean

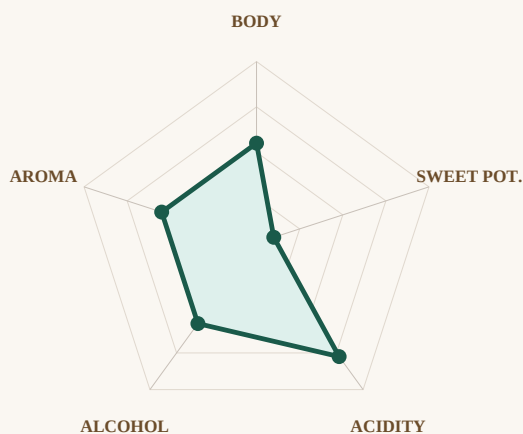


Pale Green-Yellow

Light Yellow

Yellow

Vivid Yellow



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium · structured
Sweet Potential	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Bone dry
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	High · refreshing
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium · 12.5–13.5%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Rías Baixas, Galicia, Spain
Serve	8–10 °C · White wine glass
Aging	Mostly 1–3y · premium: 5+y
Peak	1–4 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Possibly related to Alvarinho — disputed

ORIGIN & STORY

The great white wine of Spain's rainy, green northwestern coast. Rías Baixas in Galicia sits on the Atlantic — the same latitude as northern Portugal and Brittany — and gets rainfall and ocean influence unique in Spain. Thick skins protect against the region's high humidity.

The classic local pairing — Albariño with Galicia's magnificent seafood (octopus, percebes, mariscos) — is one of the world's most intuitive food and wine matches. The saline quality of the wine literally mirrors the taste of the sea. As Alvarinho in Vinho Verde, it produces fuller, premium wines.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Rías Baixas — Salnés Valley	Galicia, Spain	The definitive home — granite, Atlantic
■ ■ Vinho Verde (Alvarinho subzone)	Monção, Portugal	Fuller, more textured premium expressions
■ ■ California	USA	Santa Barbara area — gaining recognition
■ ■ Various regions	Australia	Emerging plantings by adventurous producers

ALBARIÑO

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



PRIMARY

White Peach

Apricot

Grapefruit

Lemon Zest



MARINE

Sea Brine

Saline Mineral

Sea Spray

White Flowers

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED

Almonds

Bitter Orange

Brioche

Mineral Depth

PALATE PROFILE

Albariño's defining quality is the combination of citrus freshness, stone fruit richness, and a saline marine quality that makes it taste of the ocean. The acidity is high and refreshing without being aggressive.

The finish has a characteristic slight bitterness that acts like a squeeze of lemon — it lifts the palate and makes you want another sip. In premium versions from the Salnés Valley's best sites, there is genuine mineral depth and age-worthiness beyond what most expect from the variety.

SOIL AFFINITY

Granite

Sandy

Alluvial

Schist / Slate

Mixed

PAIRS WELL WITH

Shellfish

Oysters

White Fish

Sushi

Ceviche

Tapas

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 8–10 °C · White wine glass

Aging Window Mostly 1–3y · premium: 5+y

Peak Window 1–4 years

Decanting No decanting

Famous Producers Pazo de Señoráns · Do Ferreira · Mar de Frades · Fillaboa · Adega Morgadío

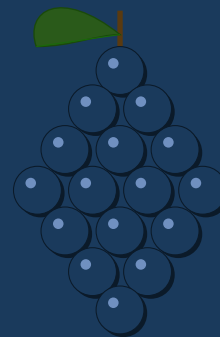
"Albariño with Galician shellfish is one of the world's most intuitive food and wine pairings — the wine tastes of the same sea."

ASSYRTIKO

■ ■ Origin: Santorini, Greece

Synonyms: Santorini's soul · Asyrtiko

Volcanic · Saline · Electric acidity · Ungrafted ancient vines

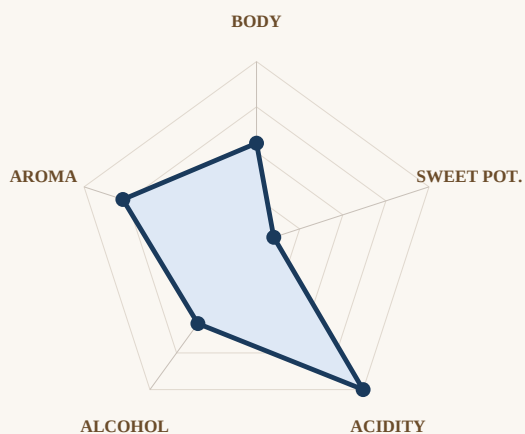


Pale Straw

Light Green-Yellow

Yellow-Green

Vivid



ATTRIBUTES

Body ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Medium · taut

Sweet Potential ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Bone dry · intense

Acidity ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Very high · extraordinary

Alcohol ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Medium · 13–14%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Santorini, Greece
Serve	8–10 °C · White wine glass
Aging	3–10y standard · Nychteri: 8–15y
Peak	3–8 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Ancient Greek variety — pre-dates recorded viticulture

ORIGIN & STORY

Greece's greatest white grape, grown on the volcanic island of Santorini in basket-trained vines called 'kouloura' — the circular shape protects grapes from the fierce Aegean winds. The volcanic pumice soils, the marine winds, and ancient ungrafted vines (phylloxera cannot survive in volcanic ash) create a wine unlike any other.

Naturally very high acidity despite the hot Mediterranean sun — the Aegean winds and volcanic cooling maintain freshness impossible at this latitude elsewhere. The 'Nychteri' style (skin contact, barrel-aged) is richer but still unmistakably Assyrtiko. Santorini has never been treated with pesticides — the volcanic sulfur protects the vines.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Santorini PDO	Greece — volcanic island	The definitive home — basket-trained, ancient
■ ■ Halkidiki · Macedonia	Northern Greece	Mainland — more accessible, less volcanic
■ ■ Various regions	Australia	Experimental — adventurous producers exploring the variety

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:

PRIMARY

Lemon

Lime

Citrus Zest

Sea Brine

MINERAL

Volcanic Mineral

Flint

Oyster Shell

Saline

Iodine

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:

 AGED	Honey	Smoked Stone	Petrol-like	Dried Citrus
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PALATE PROFILE

Assyrtiko's defining quality is its extraordinary combination of intensity and acidity — the acidity is electric, almost startling, yet the fruit intensity and mineral depth more than match it. The volcanic soils give the wine a unique smoky mineral quality with no equivalent elsewhere.

It is one of the few Mediterranean whites that can genuinely age — the acidity provides the framework while the mineral depth develops complexity over years. The Nychteri style (richer, oaked) shows a different side of the grape — broader, more textured, yet still unmistakably Santorini.

SOIL AFFINITY

Volcanic	Pumice / Ash	Basalt	Sandy
Mixed / Varied			

PAIRS WELL WITH

Grilled Octopus	Oysters	Shellfish	White Fish
Sushi	Greek Mezze		

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	8–10 °C · White wine glass
Aging Window	3–10y standard · Nychteri: 8–15y
Peak Window	3–8 years
Decanting	No decanting
Famous Producers	Santo Wines · Domaine Sigalas · Gai'a · Argyros · Hatzidakis

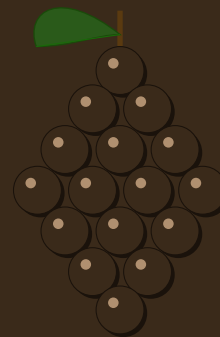
"Santorini Assyrtiko has never had phylloxera — the volcanic ash soil kills the louse. The vines are some of the oldest ungrafted on earth."

CABERNET FRANC

■ ■ Origin: Loire Valley / Bordeaux, France

Synonyms: Breton (Loire) · Bouchet (Saint-Émilion) · Carmenet

Parent of Cabernet Sauvignon · Loire's great red · Aromatic

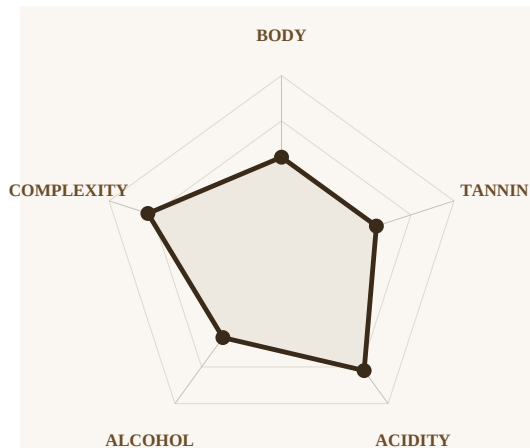


Ruby

Garnet

Medium Ruby

Warm Garnet



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium · aromatic
Tannin	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium · approachable
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	High · fresh
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Low-medium · 12–13%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Loire Valley / Bordeaux, France
Serve	16–17 °C · Burgundy glass
Aging	Loire: 5–20y · Cheval Blanc style: 20–40+y
Peak	5–15 years
Decant	30–45 min
Parentage	Parent of Cabernet Sauvignon × Sauvignon Blanc

ORIGIN & STORY

The parent grape of Cabernet Sauvignon (crossed with Sauvignon Blanc). In the Loire Valley it stands alone as the great red grape — Chinon and Bourgueil are its spiritual home. In Bordeaux it plays a crucial supporting role. Cheval Blanc — one of the most expensive wines in the world — is predominantly Cabernet Franc, proving its singular potential.

More aromatic and lighter than Cabernet Sauvignon, it has a characteristic pencil-shavings and graphite note that makes it immediately identifiable. It ripens 1–2 weeks earlier than Cab Sauv, making it valuable in cooler climates where Cabernet struggles to ripen.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Chinon · Bourgueil · Saumur	Loire Valley, France	The definitive expression — pure, mineral
■ ■ Saint-Émilion (Cheval Blanc)	Bordeaux, France	Blending partner — with occasional greatness
■ ■ Friuli-Venezia Giulia	Italy	Aromatic, fresh varietal wines
■ ■ Long Island · Finger Lakes	New York, USA	Excellent cool-climate expressions
■ ■ Mendoza	Argentina	Gaining recognition as a varietal wine

CABERNET FRANC

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:

 **FRUIT**

CassisRaspberryBlack CherryBlueberry

 **DISTINCTIVE**

Pencil ShavingsGraphiteVioletsGreen Herbs

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:

 **AGED**

TobaccoLeatherCedarDark SpiceInk

PALATE PROFILE

More aromatic and lighter than Cabernet Sauvignon, Cab Franc has the characteristic pencil-shavings and graphite note that makes it immediately identifiable. The tannins are gentler and the acidity is higher, giving the wine freshness and lift that Cabernet Sauvignon rarely achieves.

In the Loire, it is almost always unblended and expresses a pure, mineral, herb-tinged character. In Bordeaux, it adds aroma and lift to Cabernet Sauvignon blends. The wine's natural elegance and fragrance make it one of the best food-pairing reds at the table.

SOIL AFFINITY

Tufa

Clay-Limestone

Gravel

Sandy

Alluvial

PAIRS WELL WITH

Duck

Pork

Mushrooms

Goat Cheese

Salmon

Charcuterie

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	16–17 °C · Burgundy glass
Aging Window	Loire: 5–20y · Cheval Blanc style: 20–40+y
Peak Window	5–15 years
Decanting	30–45 min
Famous Producers	Cheval Blanc · Chinon Domaine Raffault · Charles Joguet · Olga Raffault · Brainerd (NY)

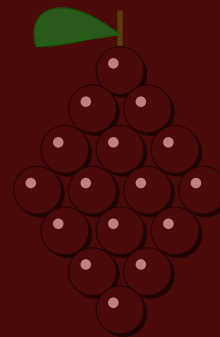
"Cheval Blanc — one of the most expensive wines in the world — is predominantly Cabernet Franc. The variety is capable of absolute greatness."

CABERNET SAUVIGNON

■ ■ Origin: Bordeaux, France

Synonyms: Bouchet (historical) · Carbonet

World's most planted fine wine grape · Age-worthy · Structured

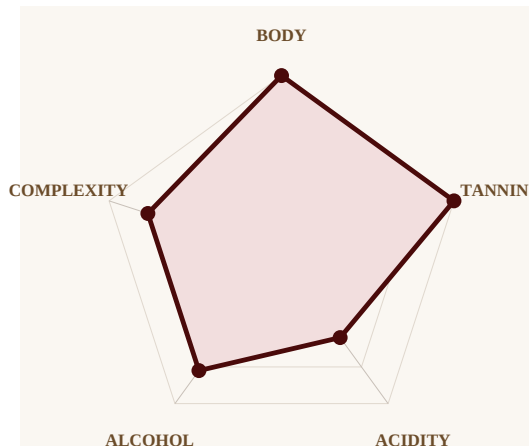


Deep Purple

Ruby

Garnet

Dark Garnet



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Full · dense · powerful
Tannin	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very high · grippy
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium-high · 13.5–15%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Bordeaux, France
Serve	17–18 °C · Bordeaux glass
Aging	15–50+ years
Peak	12–25 years
Decant	2–3 hrs young · 1 hr aged
Parentage	Cab Franc × Sauvignon Blanc (confirmed 1997)

ORIGIN & STORY

Cabernet Sauvignon was confirmed by DNA analysis in 1997 to be a natural cross between Cabernet Franc and Sauvignon Blanc — a spontaneous crossing that probably occurred in 17th-century Bordeaux. It is now the world's most planted fine wine grape, capable of producing wines that age for half a century at the highest level.

Its thick skin produces high tannins and deep colour. In cool Bordeaux, the wine is structured, mineral, and herb-tinged. In warm Napa, it becomes richer and more opulent. In Coonawarra, Australia, the terra rossa soil produces a distinctive eucalyptus note. It is the ultimate expression of tannin as a vehicle for aging.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Pauillac · Margaux · Saint-Julien	Bordeaux, France	The definitive home — Lafite, Mouton, Latour
■ ■ Napa Valley (Rutherford · Oakville)	California, USA	New World benchmark — powerful, opulent
■ ■ Santa Barbara County	California, USA	Mountain AVAs — structured, cool-influenced expressions
■ ■ Coonawarra · Margaret River	South Australia	Terra rossa soils — eucalyptus edge, elegant
■ ■ Maipo Valley	Chile	Dark fruit, cedar, eucalyptus — excellent value
■ ■ Stellenbosch	South Africa	Firm, structured, Cape herb character

CABERNET SAUVIGNON

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



DARK FRUIT

Blackcurrant

Cassis

Dark Cherry

Black Plum



HERBAL

Cedar

Tobacco Leaf

Mint

Eucalyptus

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED / COMPLEX

Cigar Box

Leather

Graphite

Pencil Shavings

Dark Chocolate

PALATE PROFILE

The most structured red in the world. Firm, grippy tannins that feel almost impenetrable when young — this is the hallmark of Cabernet Sauvignon. High in polyphenols, these tannins bind to fat and protein in food, creating the great red wine and meat pairing.

After 10–20 years the tannins polymerise into something silky and profound. The wine transforms from austere to magnificent. Cool climates (Bordeaux) show more herb, cedar, and graphite. Warm climates (Napa) show more dark fruit, chocolate, and vanilla.

SOIL AFFINITY

Gravel

Clay-Limestone

Terra Rossa

Alluvial

Volcanic

PAIRS WELL WITH

Rack of Lamb

Beef Ribeye

Duck Confit

Aged Hard Cheese

Steak

Game

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 17–18 °C · Bordeaux glass

Aging Window 15–50+ years

Peak Window 12–25 years

Decanting 2–3 hrs young · 1 hr aged

Famous Producers Châteaux Latour · Mouton Rothschild · Screaming Eagle · Penfolds Bin 707 · Almaviva

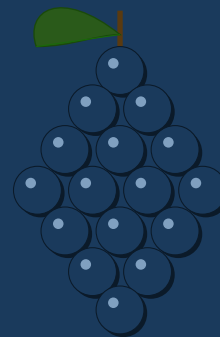
"The tannins that seem impenetrable at five years integrate into something extraordinary by twenty."

CHARDONNAY

■ ■ Origin: Burgundy, France

Synonyms: White Burgundy · Chablis · Pouilly-Fuissé · Blanc de Blancs

World's most planted white · The chameleon grape · Oak defines everything

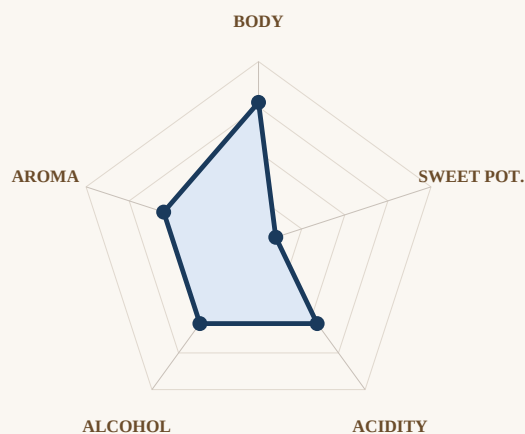


Pale Straw

Golden Straw

Deep Gold

Rich Gold



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Light to very full
Sweet Potential	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Virtually always dry
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Low (oaked) to high (unoaked)
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium · 13–14%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Burgundy, France
Serve	10–13 °C · White Burgundy glass
Aging	Most: 1–5y · Grand Cru Burgundy: 10–30+y
Peak	3–15 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Pinot Noir × Gouais Blanc (confirmed DNA 1999)

ORIGIN & STORY

The world's most planted and most versatile white wine grape. In cold Chablis with Kimmeridgian limestone, it produces steely, mineral wine. In warm Napa with heavy oak, it is buttery and tropical. The decision of whether to use malolactic fermentation — converting sharp malic acid to soft lactic acid — is the single most consequential winemaking choice.

A natural cross of Pinot Noir and Gouais Blanc, confirmed by DNA in 1999. The greatest examples come from the Côte de Beaune — Meursault, Puligny-Montrachet, Chassagne-Montrachet — where the combination of Jurassic limestone soils and skilled winemaking produces wines of extraordinary richness and longevity.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Chablis · Meursault · Puligny	Burgundy, France	The benchmark across all styles
■ ■ Napa · Russian River	California, USA	Rich, oaked, tropical
■ ■ Santa Barbara County	California, USA	Sta. Rita Hills — elegant, mineral, cool-driven
■ ■ Yarra · Adelaide Hills	Australia	Elegant, cool-climate, Burgundian
■ ■ Hawke's Bay · Marlborough	New Zealand	Fresh, fruit-driven
■ ■ Champagne	France	Blanc de Blancs — base of the world's finest bubbles

CHARDONNAY

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



COOL CLIMATE

Lemon

Green Apple

Flint

Chalk

Citrus Zest



WARM / OAKED

Butter

Hazelnut

Tropical Fruit

Peach

Vanilla

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED

Honey

Toasted Nuts

Caramel

Beeswax

Butterscotch

PALATE PROFILE

The most versatile white grape — the wine it produces depends almost entirely on where it's grown and how it's made. In Chablis: lean, mineral, saline, almost austere. In Meursault: rich, hazelnut-scented, creamy, profound. In Napa: lush, buttery, tropical, immediately rewarding.

The oak-aged, MLF-converted version and the naked, unoaked version are essentially different wines from the same grape. Matching the style to the food is the key. With a cream-based dish, oaked Chardonnay is perfect. With oysters, nothing beats Chablis.

SOIL AFFINITY

Kimmeridgian Clay

Limestone

Clay-Limestone

Sandy

Alluvial

PAIRS WELL WITH

Lobster

Shellfish

White Fish

Chicken

Pasta

Soft Cheese

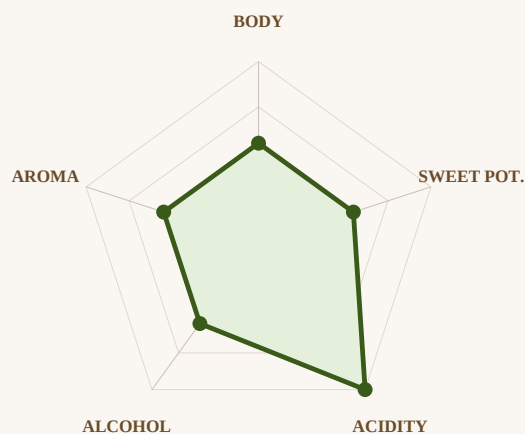
IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	10–13 °C · White Burgundy glass
Aging Window	Most: 1–5y · Grand Cru Burgundy: 10–30+y
Peak Window	3–15 years
Decanting	No decanting
Famous Producers	Domaine Leflaive · Coche-Dury · Raveneau (Chablis) · Kistler (Napa) · Leeuwin Estate (AUS)

"An unoaked Chablis and a Napa Chardonnay are the same grape — everything different between them is a winemaker's decision."

■■ *Origin: Loire Valley, France*

Most versatile white grape · Bone dry to dessert · Ages magnificently



Body		<i>Light to full</i>
Sweet Potential		<i>Dry to intensely sweet</i>
Acidity		<i>Very high · laser-like</i>
Alcohol		<i>Medium · 12.5–14%</i>

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Loire Valley, France
Serve	9–12 °C · White Burgundy glass
Aging	Dry: 5–20y · Sweet botrytis: 30–50+y
Peak	5–20 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Ancient Loire variety — 9th century

The most versatile white grape in the world — makes bone-dry mineral wines (Savennières), off-dry (Vouvray demi-sec), sparkling (Crémant de Loire), and some of the world's greatest sweet wines (Quarts de Chaume, Coteaux du Layon). Its very high acidity gives it the structure to age for decades even in dry styles.

South Africa has become its second great home: old-vine Chenin from Swartland produces wines of extraordinary complexity from bush vines planted 50–80 years ago. The beeswax aroma that develops in aged Chenin is unique and unmistakable — one of wine's great acquired pleasures.

■■ Vouvray · Savennières	Loire, France	Bone dry to lusciously sweet — same village
■■ Coteaux du Layon · Quarts de Chaume	Loire, France	The great botrytis sweet wines
■■ Swartland · Stellenbosch (Steen)	South Africa	Old vine — complex, textured, world-class
■■ Saumur · Anjou	Loire, France	Sparkling and still expressions
■■ California	USA	Fresh, fruit-forward expressions

CHENIN BLANC

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



DRY

Quince

Green Apple

Beeswax

Chamomile



OFF-DRY

Pear

Honey

Ginger

White Peach

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



SWEET / AGED

Apricot

Marmalade

Saffron

Lanolin

Dried Apricot

PALATE PROFILE

Chenin Blanc's defining characteristic is its combination of very high acidity with a naturally rich, waxy texture — a paradox that gives it balance and longevity across all sweetness levels. In Savennières (dry), the wine is almost austere, mineral, and demanding — requiring patience.

In Vouvray demi-sec it is perfectly balanced: sweet enough to satisfy, acidic enough to remain fresh. In the great botrytis sweet wines, the combination of honey richness and rapier-like acidity creates wines that can genuinely age a century. Beeswax is the most distinctive aged character.

SOIL AFFINITY

Tufa

Schist / Slate

Clay

Sandy

Limestone

PAIRS WELL WITH

Roast Chicken

Pork

Smoked Fish

Brie

Goat Cheese

Foie Gras

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 9–12 °C · White Burgundy glass

Aging Window Dry: 5–20y · Sweet botrytis: 30–50+y

Peak Window 5–20 years

Decanting No decanting

Famous Producers Nicolas Joly (Savennières) · Domaine Huet (Vouvray) · Eben Sadie (SA) · AA Badenhorst

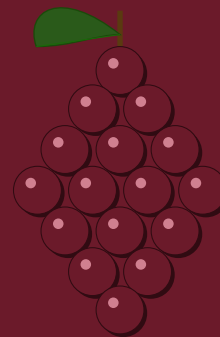
"Savennières at 20 years and Quarts de Chaume at 50 years — the same grape producing wines at opposite ends of the spectrum, each extraordinary."

GAMAY

■ ■ Origin: Beaujolais, France

Synonyms: Gamay Noir à Jus Blanc

Wine's most misunderstood grape · Serve chilled · Cru Gamay is serious

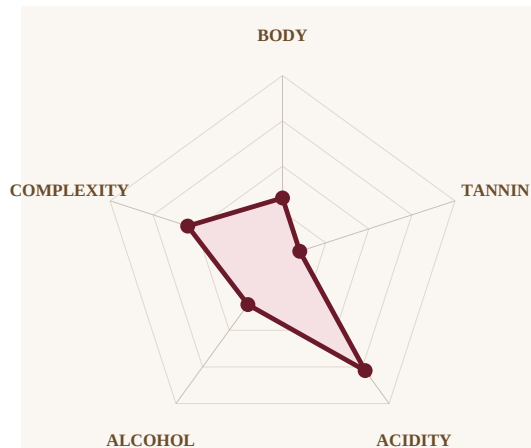


Bright Ruby

Ruby

Light Ruby

Pale Ruby



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Light · transparent
Tannin	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very low · silky
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	High · fresh
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Low · 11–13%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Beaujolais, France
Serve	14–15 °C (chilled) · Burgundy glass
Aging	Nouveau: drink now · Crus: 5–15y
Peak	3–10 years (Cru)
Decant	No decanting needed
Parentage	Ancient Burgundian variety

ORIGIN & STORY

Beaujolais Nouveau made Gamay internationally famous — and nearly destroyed its reputation by making the variety synonymous with cheap wine. The ten Beaujolais Crus (Morgon, Moulin-à-Vent, Fleurie) are completely different: serious, terroir-driven wines of genuine depth and age-worthiness.

Gamay was banned from Burgundy in 1395 by Philip the Bold as 'a very bad and disloyal plant' — likely because it outproduced and outsold Pinot Noir. Morgon's decomposed granite gives it a character sometimes compared to aged Burgundy. Carbonic maceration (the Nouveau technique) creates banana-cherry freshness with no tannin.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Beaujolais Crus (Morgon, Fleurie)	France — granite and schist	Serious, mineral, age-worthy expressions
■ ■ Moulin-à-Vent	Beaujolais, France	Manganese-rich soil — the most Pinot-like Cru
■ ■ Touraine · Loire	France	Lighter, earlier-drinking
■ ■ Switzerland	Multiple cantons	Domestic favourite — fresh, mineral
■ ■ Ontario	Canada	Cool-climate expressions — growing quality

GAMAY

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



FRUIT

Fresh Cherry

Raspberry

Strawberry

Cranberry



FLORAL

Violet

Rose Water

Peony

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED CRU

Granite Mineral

Earth

Mushroom

Dark Cherry

Iron

PALATE PROFILE

The benchmark chillable red. Very low tannin, high freshness, vivid red fruit — Gamay is wine at its most immediately pleasurable. Serve at 14–15°C for best results: slightly chilled enhances the freshness without masking the flavour.

Carbonic maceration (the Nouveau technique) ferments whole bunches in CO₂, producing banana-cherry fruit with zero tannin. The Cru versions, made conventionally, have real structure and age beautifully — Morgon in particular can develop like Burgundy Pinot Noir after 5–10 years.

SOIL AFFINITY

Granite

Schist / Slate

Sandy

Basalt

Clay-Limestone

PAIRS WELL WITH

Charcuterie

Chicken

Light Fish

Goat Cheese

Pizza

Tapas

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 14–15 °C (chilled) · Burgundy glass

Aging Window Nouveau: drink now · Crus: 5–15y

Peak Window 3–10 years (Cru)

Decanting No decanting needed

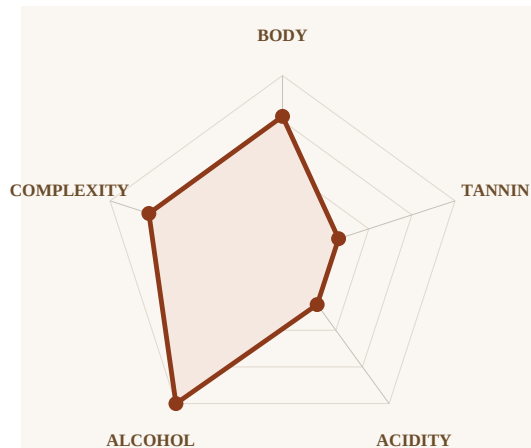
Famous Producers Marcel Lapierre · Jean Foillard · Louis-Claude Desvignes · Guy Breton · Château Thivin

"Philip the Bold banned Gamay from Burgundy in 1395. The greatest wine industry decision never reversed."

■ ■ *Origin: Southern France / Aragon, Spain*

Synonyms: Garnacha (Spain) · Cannonau (Sardinia) · Grenache Noir

World's second most planted red · Mediterranean · Warm · Spiced



Body		Full · warm
Tannin		Low · soft
Acidity		Low · round
Alcohol		Very high · 14.5–16%

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Southern France / Aragon, Spain
Serve	17 °C · Large Burgundy or Bordeaux glass
Aging	3–15y · Old vine CdP/Priorat: 15–25y
Peak	5–15 years
Decant	1 hr
Parentage	Possibly from Aragon (Spain) or Sardinia

ORIGIN & STORY

The world's second most planted red grape, Grenache thrives in hot, dry, windswept Mediterranean conditions. Château Rayas — 100% old-vine Grenache — is considered one of France's most celebrated wines, proving the variety's singular potential when treated as the lead rather than a blending grape.

Its naturally high alcohol, low acidity, and low tannin create a wine that is warm, generous, and immediately approachable. In the Southern Rhône it is blended with Syrah and Mourvèdre. In Priorat on black slate it becomes extraordinarily concentrated. Barossa's 100+ year old bush vines produce some of Australia's most intense wines.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■■■ Châteauneuf-du-Pape · Gigondas	Southern Rhône, France	The definitive expression — Château Rayas
■■■ Priorat	Catalonia, Spain	On black slate (llicorella) — extraordinary concentration
■■■ Barossa Valley	South Australia	Old-vine bush vines — 100+ years old, intense
■■■ Santa Barbara · Paso Robles	California, USA	Rhône-focused producers — growing reputation
■■■ Sardinia (Cannonau)	Italy	Lighter, herbaceous, ancient expression
■■■ Roussillon	Southern France	Robust, spiced — great GSM blends

GRENACHE

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



RED FRUIT

Red Berry

Strawberry

Kirsch

White Cherry



HERBAL

Garrigue

Dried Herbs

Rosemary

Lavender

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED

Dried Fruit

Leather

Tobacco

White Pepper

Spice

PALATE PROFILE

Low natural tannin and acidity makes Grenache soft and generous from the start. The wine feels warm, almost sweet, because of the naturally high alcohol — often 14.5–16%. In the Southern Rhône it blends with Syrah (structure) and Mourvèdre (longevity).

The garrigue (wild Mediterranean herb) aroma is characteristic and unmistakable — rosemary, lavender, dried thyme in the glass. Old vines produce concentrated wines of remarkable depth. Priorat and Barossa examples from very old vines rival the finest wines in the world for pure intensity.

SOIL AFFINITY

Schist / Slate

Sandy

Gravel

Limestone

Mixed / Varied

PAIRS WELL WITH

Lamb Tagine

Charcuterie

Tapas

Spiced Dishes

Pizza

Game

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 17 °C · Large Burgundy or Bordeaux glass

Aging Window 3–15y · Old vine CdP/Priorat: 15–25y

Peak Window 5–15 years

Decanting 1 hr

Famous Producers Château Rayas · Palacios Remondo · Clos des Papes · Two Hands · Torbreck

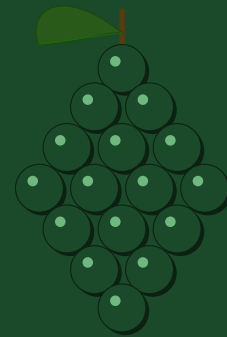
"Old-vine Grenache from Priorat or Barossa bush vines is among the most complex and concentrated wine on earth."

GRÜNER VELTLINER

■ ■ Origin: Wachau, Austria

Synonyms: GrüVe · Grüner

Austria's soul grape · White pepper fingerprint · Works with asparagus

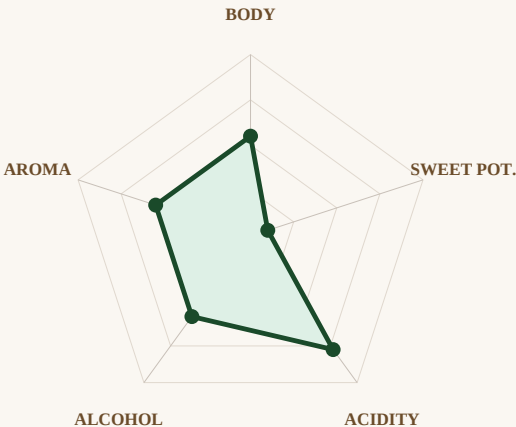


Pale Yellow-Green

Light Yellow

Fresh Yellow

Vivid



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Light to medium
Sweet Potential	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Almost always dry
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	High · precise
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium · 12–14%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Wachau, Austria
Serve	9–11 °C · White wine glass
Aging	Most: 1–5y · Wachau Smaragd: 8–15y
Peak	3–10 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Complex ancestry — Traminer and Burgundian varieties

ORIGIN & STORY

Austria's flagship white grape and one of the great underappreciated varieties. The white pepper note — from the compound rotundone — is so distinctive that it serves as Grüner Veltliner's fingerprint. The Wachau classification (Steinfeder, Federspiel, Smaragd) represents three quality tiers named after local creatures.

Its natural affinity with asparagus — a notoriously wine-hostile vegetable — is one of wine's great discoveries. The rotundone (pepper) compound in Grüner Veltliner bridges to the vegetable's sulphurous character in a way no other grape manages. Knoll, Hirsch, and Bründlmayer are benchmark producers.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Wachau (Smaragd tier)	Lower Austria	The finest expression — granite, Danube
■ ■ Kamptal · Kremstal	Lower Austria	Elegant, mineral, excellent value
■ ■ Weinviertel DAC	Lower Austria	Lighter, everyday style — great for summer
■ ■ Moravia	Czech Republic	Neighbouring expressions — fresh, crisp

GRÜNER VELTLINER

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



DEFINING

White Pepper

Lime

Citrus Zest

Green Herb



FRUIT

Grapefruit

White Peach

Apple

Lemon

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED SMARAGD

Mineral

Almond

Smoke

Honey

White Truffle

PALATE PROFILE

The white pepper note is the defining sensory marker — it appears on both nose and palate and is unmistakable. The acidity is high and refreshing without aggression. The wine feels clean and precise. Steinfeder (lightest) is delicate; Federspiel is structured; Smaragd (finest) is powerful and built for aging.

Served with Wiener Schnitzel — Austria's classic pairing — the peppery note harmonizes with the crisp golden coating perfectly. Grüner Veltliner is also the only wine that handles asparagus with genuine success — the rotundone bridges the vegetable's sulphurous character.

SOIL AFFINITY

Alluvial

Limestone

Loam

Clay

Sandy

Loess

PAIRS WELL WITH

Wiener Schnitzel

Asparagus

Sushi

Vegetables

White Fish

Mushrooms

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 9–11 °C · White wine glass

Aging Window Most: 1–5y · Wachau Smaragd: 8–15y

Peak Window 3–10 years

Decanting No decanting

Famous Producers F.X. Pichler · Emmerich Knoll · Hirsch · Bründlmayer · Loimer · Rudi Pichler

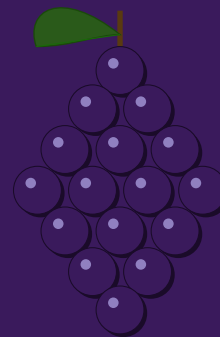
"Grüner Veltliner is the only wine that handles asparagus — a vegetable that makes almost every other wine taste metallic."

MALBEC

■ ■ Origin: Cahors, France

Synonyms: Côt (Loire) · Auxerrois (Cahors) · Pressac

From French obscurity to Argentina's national grape

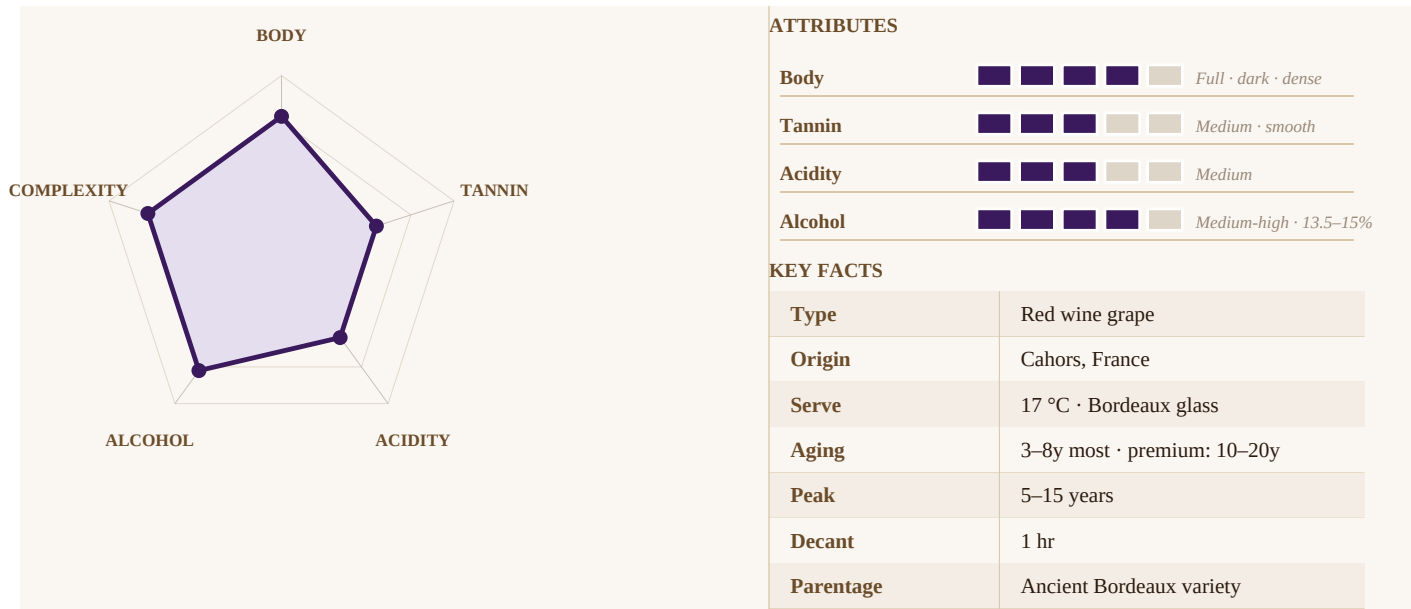


Deep Purple

Inky Purple

Purple-Ruby

Dark



ORIGIN & STORY

Originally from Bordeaux and Southwest France (Cahors), Malbec found its greatest expression in Argentina. The intense UV radiation at high altitude (900–1,500m) produces thick-skinned grapes with deep colour and natural richness unlike anything possible in France. DNA profiling confirmed the Argentinian Malbec and French Côt are the same grape.

Zuccardi Valle de Uco was named World's Best Winery three consecutive years — a vindication of the variety's extraordinary potential in the Andes. The violet and dark fruit aromatics are unmistakable, and the combination of concentration and smooth tannin makes it one of the world's most crowd-pleasing fine wine grapes.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Mendoza (Luján de Cuyo)	Argentina	The adopted home — world-class at every level
■ ■ Uco Valley (high altitude)	Argentina — 900–1,500m	Most structured, mineral expressions
■ ■ Cahors AOC	France — original home	Dark, rustic, structured — Auxerrois style
■ ■ Maipo · Colchagua	Chile	Secondary South American expression
■ ■ Langhorne Creek	South Australia	Soft, plush, excellent value

MALBEC

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:

 FRUIT	Dark Plum Blackberry Blueberry Black Cherry
 FLORAL	Violet Dark Rose Lilac

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:

 AGED	Chocolate Tobacco Leather Coffee Dark Spice
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PALATE PROFILE

The most distinctive characteristic is the combination of dark, dense colour and relatively smooth tannins — more approachable than Cabernet Sauvignon at a similar concentration level. The violet and floral aromatics are one of its most recognizable traits.

High altitude amplifies acidity and structure while preserving freshness. Argentine Malbec at its best has genuine complexity and age-worthiness. Most entry-level versions are designed for immediate pleasure — and deliver it consistently.

SOIL AFFINITY

Alluvial	Clay	Sandy	Limestone
Mixed / Varied			

PAIRS WELL WITH

Beef Asado	Lamb Chops	Charcuterie	BBQ
Game	Steak		

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	17 °C · Bordeaux glass
Aging Window	3–8y most · premium: 10–20y
Peak Window	5–15 years
Decanting	1 hr
Famous Producers	Zuccardi · Achaval Ferrer · Catena Zapata · Clos de los Siete · Clos Apalta (Chile)

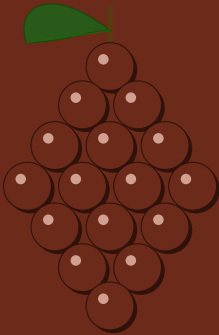
"Malbec found its greatest expression not in its French homeland but 12,000km away on the slopes of the Andes at 1,000m altitude."

MERLOT

■ ■ Origin: Bordeaux, France

Synonyms: Bigney (historical)

World's most planted red · Plush · Approachable · Underrated

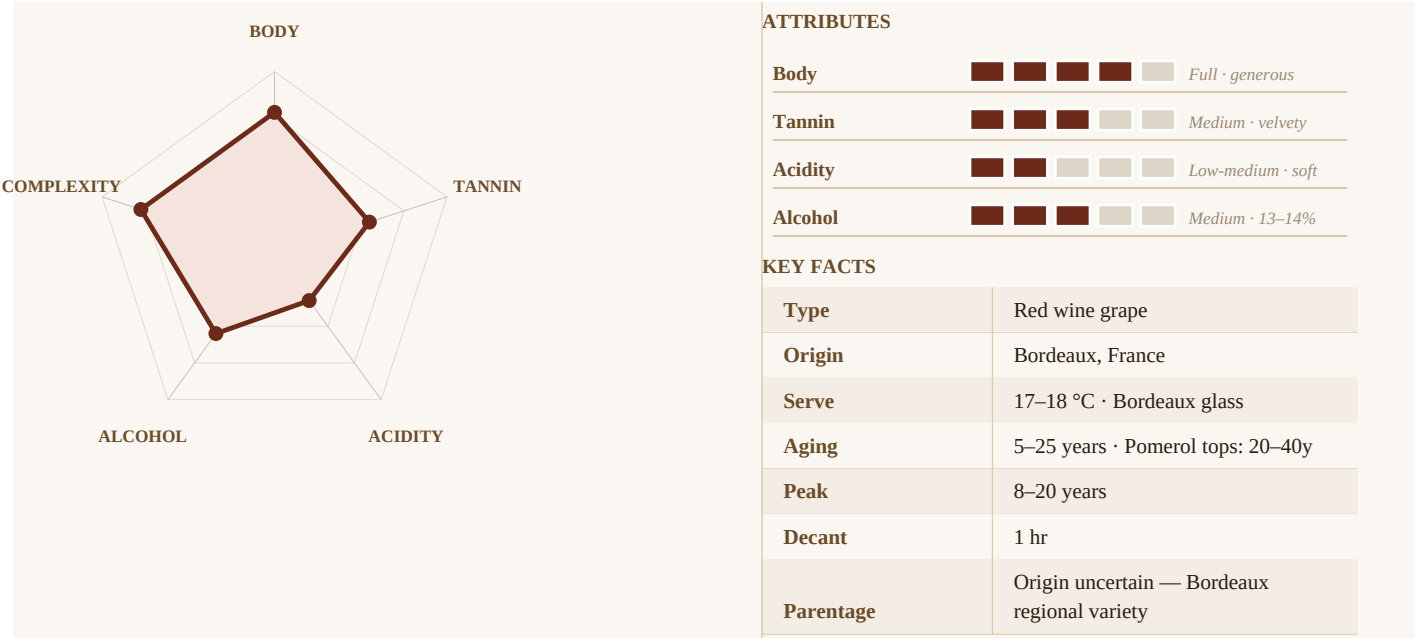


Deep Ruby

Ruby

Warm Garnet

Dark



ORIGIN & STORY

The world's most planted red grape, yet chronically undervalued due to the oversimplified Sideways narrative. In Bordeaux's Right Bank — Pomerol and Saint-Émilion — it produces wines of extraordinary depth. Pétrus, the most expensive wine in the world by bottle, is almost entirely Merlot.

Merlot's thinner skin compared to Cabernet Sauvignon means lower tannin and an earlier-ripening, more approachable wine. On clay soils (Pomerol), it develops remarkable weight and complexity. The blue clay of Château Pétrus's plateau holds heat and moisture — perfect conditions for Merlot to achieve greatness.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Pomerol · Saint-Émilion	Right Bank Bordeaux	The finest expression — Pétrus, Cheval Blanc
■ ■ Napa · Columbia Valley	USA	Richer, plummier, more accessible style
■ ■ Colchagua · Maipo	Chile	Supple, fruit-forward — excellent value
■ ■ Tuscany	Italy	Key blending partner in Super Tuscans
■ ■ Margaret River	Western Australia	Elegant, Bordeaux-like expressions

MERLOT

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:

FRUIT	Dark Plum	Black Cherry	Blueberry	Red Plum
SAVOURY	Bay Leaf	Chocolate	Mocha	Coffee

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:

AGED	Truffle	Tobacco	Leather	Dark Spice	Vanilla
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PALATE PROFILE

Softer and more immediately approachable than Cabernet Sauvignon due to thinner skins and lower tannin. The texture is plush and generous — what critics describe as 'fleshy'. On clay soils like Pomerol, it develops extraordinary weight and complexity.

The acidity is naturally lower, contributing to its immediate drinkability and the wine's round, generous palate feel. In warm climates it can become jammy and over-ripe — precision in picking time is critical. Great Pomerol Merlot is one of the most hedonistic wines on earth.

SOIL AFFINITY

Iron-rich Clay	Gravel	Limestone	Alluvial
Sandy			

PAIRS WELL WITH

Beef	Duck	Pasta Bolognese	Mushroom Risotto
Veal	Charcuterie		

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	17–18 °C · Bordeaux glass
Aging Window	5–25 years · Pomerol tops: 20–40y
Peak Window	8–20 years
Decanting	1 hr
Famous Producers	Pétrus · Le Pin · Lafleur · L'Evangile · Duckhorn · Leonetti

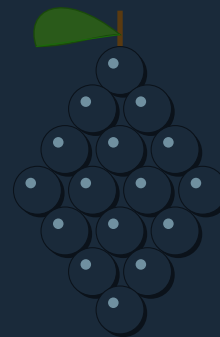
"Pétrus — one of the world's most expensive wines — is almost 100% Merlot. The grape is misunderstood, not mediocre."

MOURVÈDRE

■ ■ Origin: Provence / Murcia, France & Spain

Synonyms: Monastrell (Spain) · Mataro (Australia/California)

The M in GSM · Bandol's soul · Needs serious food

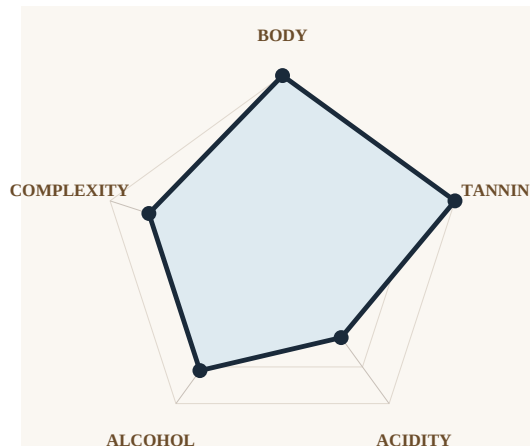


Purple-Black

Inky

Dark Ruby

Very Dark



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very full · dense
Tannin	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very high · formidable
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	High · 14–15.5%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Provence / Murcia, France & Spain
Serve	17–18 °C · Bordeaux glass
Aging	Bandol: 10–25+y
Peak	10–20 years
Decant	2–3 hrs
Parentage	Possibly from Murcia, Spain originally

ORIGIN & STORY

The M in GSM (Grenache-Syrah-Mourvèdre) blends. In Bandol, Provence, it stands alone and produces one of France's most structured, most gamey, most long-lived red wines. Needs very warm conditions to ripen fully — underripe it tastes harsh and iron-heavy; fully ripe it develops extraordinary complexity with age.

In Spain as Monastrell, it makes dark, powerful wines in Jumilla and Yecla — a completely different expression of the same grape. The wine's inherently meaty, animal character divides opinion but is considered a mark of authenticity. After 10–15 years the harsh edges integrate and the wine reveals itself.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Bandol AOC	Provence, France	The definitive home — Domaine Tempier
■ ■ Châteauneuf-du-Pape	Southern Rhône	Essential blending partner for longevity
■ ■ Jumilla · Yecla (Monastrell)	Murcia, Spain	Dense, powerful, dark fruit
■ ■ Barossa · McLaren Vale	South Australia	Celebrated as Mataro — old vine intensity
■ ■ Santa Barbara · Paso Robles	California, USA	Rhône Rangers movement — serious expressions

MOURVÈDRE

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



FRUIT

Blackberry

Black Olive

Dark Plum

Blueberry



SAVOURY

Game

Leather

Iron

Garrigue

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED

Truffle

Smoke

Tar

Meat

Dark Spice

PALATE PROFILE

Bandol Mourvèdre is one of the most gastronomic wines in France — deeply savoury, meaty, structured, built for the long haul. The tannins are formidable when young. The wine's gamey, almost animal character divides opinion but is considered a mark of authenticity.

After 10–15 years, the harsh edges integrate and the wine becomes complex, profound, and distinctive. In blends, it provides the structure, longevity, and earthy depth that neither Grenache nor Syrah can supply alone. It is the backbone of great GSM blends.

SOIL AFFINITY

Limestone

Clay

Schist / Slate

Sandy

Volcanic

PAIRS WELL WITH

Game

Lamb

Charcuterie

Hard Cheese

Cassoulet

BBQ

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 17–18 °C · Bordeaux glass

Aging Window Bandol: 10–25+y

Peak Window 10–20 years

Decanting 2–3 hrs

Famous Producers Domaine Tempier · Château Pibarnon · Château Pradeaux · Bodegas El Nido (Spain)

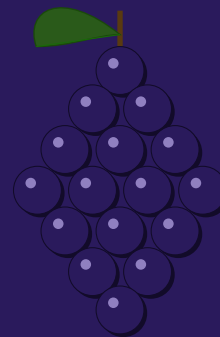
"Bandol Mourvèdre at ten years is one of the most deeply savoury, most gastronomic wines in France — built for the table, not the couch."

NEBBIOLO

■ ■ Origin: Piedmont, Italy

Synonyms: Spanna · Chiavennasca (Valtellina) · Picotèner

The King of wines · Never open early · Tar and roses

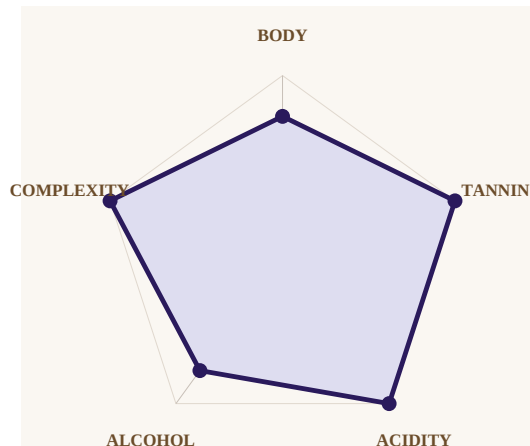


Pale Garnet

Ruby-Garnet

Light Garnet

Brick



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Full but pale-coloured
Tannin	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Ferocious · formidable
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very high · long-lived
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium-high · 14–15%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Piedmont, Italy
Serve	18 °C · Large Burgundy glass
Aging	Barolo: 15–40+y · Barbaresco: 12–30y
Peak	15–30 years
Decant	3–4 hrs young wines
Parentage	Ancient Piedmontese variety

ORIGIN & STORY

Named after the fog (nebbia) of the Langhe hills, Nebbiolo is the most paradoxical grape: pale in colour but monstrous in tannin and acidity. Virtually undrinkable young — a great Barolo needs 15–20 years to begin revealing itself. Virtually no commercial plantings exist outside Piedmont.

The 'tar and roses' descriptor is unique in the wine world — simultaneously austere (tar) and perfumed (roses) — and appears in no other grape. The debate between traditionalists (large Slavonian oak, 5+ year aging) and modernists (French barrique, shorter maceration) defined Barolo for decades.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Barolo DOCG	Piedmont — La Morra, Serralunga, Barolo commune	The King of wines — needs 10–20 years
■ ■ Barbaresco DOCG	Piedmont — Treiso, Neive, Barbaresco	The Queen — more elegant, earlier maturing
■ ■ Langhe DOC	Piedmont	Earlier drinking expressions of the same grape
■ ■ Valtellina (Sforzato)	Lombardy — Alpine expression	High altitude, lighter, distinctive mineral
■ ■ Roero	Piedmont — across the Tanaro	Sandier soils, more delicate and aromatic

NEBBIOLO

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



PRIMARY

Dried Cherry

Tar

Dried Rose

Violets



EARTH

Tobacco

Licorice

Leather

Iron

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED (10+ YRS)

Truffle

Camphor

Dried Fruit

Forest Floor

Anise

PALATE PROFILE

The most demanding wine to appreciate young. The tannins are not just firm — they are ferociously astringent, almost drying the mouth completely. The acidity is simultaneously very high, adding to the wine's structural tension. This combination makes young Barolo virtually undrinkable for most people.

After 15–20 years, these seemingly impenetrable elements integrate into something of extraordinary complexity — silky, layered, with depth that reveals itself slowly. The hallmark 'tar and roses' pairing — simultaneously austere and perfumed — is unique to this grape. Great Barolo is among the longest-lived wines on earth.

SOIL AFFINITY

Limestone

Clay-Limestone

Tufa

Sandstone

Marlstone

PAIRS WELL WITH

White Truffle

Braised Beef

Aged Parmesan

Wild Mushrooms

Game

Veal

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 18 °C · Large Burgundy glass

Aging Window Barolo: 15–40+y · Barbaresco: 12–30y

Peak Window 15–30 years

Decanting 3–4 hrs young wines

Famous Producers Gaja · Giacomo Conterno · Bruno Giacosa · Roberto Voerzio · Aldo Conterno · Vietti

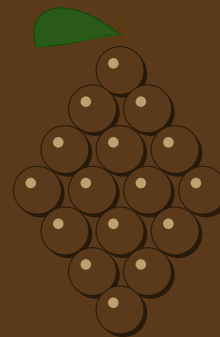
"Tar and roses — the two aromas that define Nebbiolo are as contradictory and as inseparable as the grape itself."

RIESLING

■ ■ Origin: Rhine / Mosel, Germany

Synonyms: Most misunderstood great grape in the world

Dry to lusciously sweet · Petrol with age · Ages magnificently

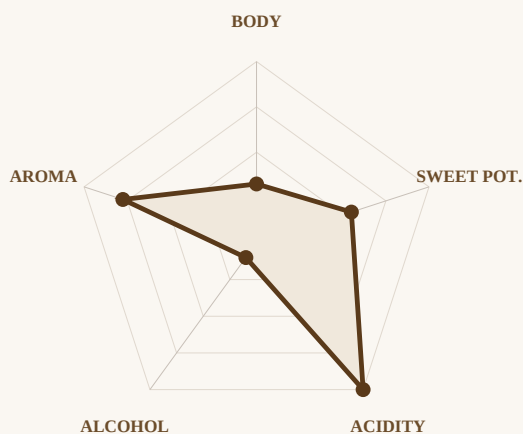


Pale Straw

Golden Straw

Gold

Deep Gold



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Light · delicate
Sweet Potential	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Bone dry to intensely sweet
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very high · electric
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very low · 7–12%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Rhine / Mosel, Germany
Serve	8–10 °C · White wine glass
Aging	Dry: 5–15y · TBA: 30–50+y
Peak	5–20 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Ancient Rhine variety

ORIGIN & STORY

The world's most misunderstood great grape. Most Riesling is dry or off-dry — not sweet — but the German Prädikat labelling confuses everyone. Naturally very high acid, low alcohol (7–10% in the best German versions), it ripens early and preserves aromatic freshness. The TDN compound that creates 'petrol' aroma after 5–10 years is a mark of quality.

Egon Müller's Scharzhofberger TBA is one of the world's most expensive wines — a testament to what Riesling can achieve at its sweetest extreme. Australia's Clare and Eden Valleys produce extraordinary dry Rieslings that age magnificently, developing petrol and toasted honey over 10–20 years.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Mosel Slate Valleys	Germany	The pinnacle — slate mineral, laser acidity
■ ■ Rheingau · Nahe	Germany	Fuller, more powerful, structured
■ ■ Alsace Grand Cru	France	Dry, intensely aromatic — a different world
■ ■ Clare Valley · Eden Valley	South Australia	Lime, petrol aged — stunning 20-year wines
■ ■ Wachau (Smaragd)	Austria	Powerful, mineral — rivals Alsace Grand Cru

RIESLING

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



PRIMARY

Lime

Green Apple

Apricot

White Peach

Lemon



MINERAL

Slate

Flint

Wet Stone

Petrol (TDN aged)

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



SWEET / AGED

Honey

Orange Blossom

Saffron

Marmalade

Kerosene

PALATE PROFILE

Riesling's defining characteristic is its electric acidity — a spine of freshness that runs through every style from bone dry to lusciously sweet. Low alcohol (often 7–9%) means the wine never feels heavy, and the acidity gives even the sweetest versions a sense of tension rather than cloying richness.

The range of styles is unique: Kabinett (delicate, barely sweet) through TBA (concentrated, intensely sweet, with acidity that counterbalances everything) — all from the same grape. The petrol/kerosene note that develops after 5–10 years is one of wine's great acquired tastes.

SOIL AFFINITY

Schist / Slate

Granite

Limestone

Sandy

Marlstone

PAIRS WELL WITH

Pork

Spiced Dishes

Thai Cuisine

Sushi

Duck

Asian Food

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp 8–10 °C · White wine glass

Aging Window Dry: 5–15y · TBA: 30–50+y

Peak Window 5–20 years

Decanting No decanting

Famous Producers Egon Müller · Moselland · J.J. Prüm · Donnhoff · Trimbach · Grosset (Clare Valley)

"Riesling is the world's most misunderstood great grape — most of it is dry, most of it is magnificent, and almost none of it gets the credit it deserves."

■ ■ *Origin: Tuscany, Italy*

Synonyms: Brunello · Prugnolo Gentile · Morellino · Nielluccio (Corsica)

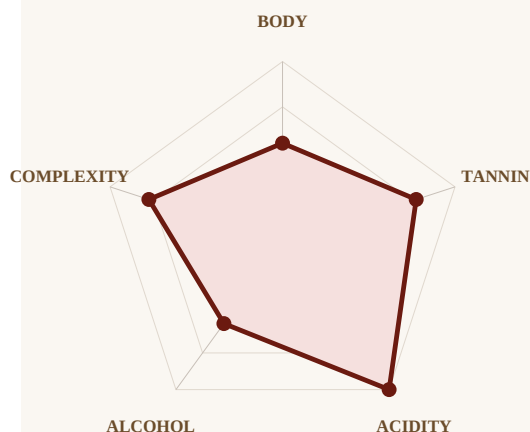
Italy's most planted red · Born for food · Defines Tuscany

Ruby

Garnet

Bright Ruby

Warm Garnet



Body		Medium · food-driven
Tannin		High · drying
Acidity		Very high · mouth-watering
Alcohol		Medium · 13–14%

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Tuscany, Italy
Serve	17–18 °C · Large Bordeaux glass
Aging	Chianti: 5–15y · Brunello Riserva: 20–40+y
Peak	8–25 years
Decant	1–2 hrs
Parentage	Ancient Tuscan variety

Italy's most planted and most important red grape. The name derives from 'Sanguis Jovis' — blood of Jupiter — reflecting its ancient presence. Its defining characteristic is very high natural acidity, which makes it supremely food-friendly and gives Brunello di Montalcino one of the longest aging potentials of any wine.

Biondi-Santi created the modern concept of Brunello in the 1880s by selecting the finest local Sangiovese clone. The result is a wine that requires minimum 5 years aging before release and can improve for 40 years or more. Chianti Classico, the heartland expression, is one of Italy's most versatile food wines.

■■ Chianti Classico DOCG	Tuscany — Gallo Nero heartland	The everyday expression at its finest
■■ Brunello di Montalcino DOCG	Tuscany	The pinnacle — 5+ year aging minimum
■■ Vino Nobile di Montepulciano	Tuscany	Complex, structured, Brunello's sibling
■■ Morellino di Scansano	Tuscany	Warmer, more accessible, coastal influence
■■ Corsica (Nielluccio)	France	Distinctive mineral, Atlantic-influenced

SANGIOVESE

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:

 FRUIT	<i>Sour Cherry</i>	<i>Dried Cherry</i>	<i>Red Plum</i>	<i>Tomato Leaf</i>
 EARTH	<i>Leather</i>	<i>Tobacco</i>	<i>Dried Herbs</i>	<i>Dried Rose</i>

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:

 AGED	<i>Balsamic</i>	<i>Truffle</i>	<i>Licorice</i>	<i>Dark Spice</i>	<i>Iron</i>
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PALATE PROFILE

The defining sensory characteristic is its mouth-watering, almost aggressive acidity — it makes you salivate, which is exactly what makes it such a perfect food partner. Tannins are firm and drying rather than grippy. In Brunello, years of aging transform these tough tannins into extraordinary complexity.

Flavours lean savoury rather than fruity — tomato leaf, leather, dried herbs — making it one of the most food-centric grapes. Think of it less as a pleasure-driven grape and more as a cuisine companion. With Bistecca Fiorentina or a rich tomato pasta, the pairing is a revelation.

SOIL AFFINITY

<i>Clay-Limestone</i>	<i>Galestro (shale)</i>	<i>Alluvial</i>	<i>Sandy</i>
<i>Tufa</i>			

PAIRS WELL WITH

<i>Bistecca Fiorentina</i>	<i>Pasta al Ragù</i>	<i>Pizza</i>	<i>Salumi</i>
<i>Hard Cheese</i>	<i>Game</i>		

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	17–18 °C · Large Bordeaux glass
Aging Window	Chianti: 5–15y · Brunello Riserva: 20–40+y
Peak Window	8–25 years
Decanting	1–2 hrs
Famous Producers	Biondi-Santi · Sassicaia (blends) · Isole e Olena · Antinori Pèppoli · Frescobaldi

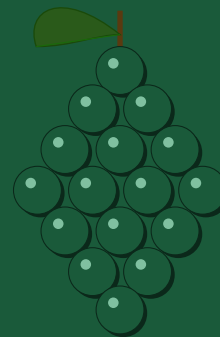
"Sangiovese's defining characteristic is its mouth-watering acidity — it makes the wine salivate-inducing, which is exactly what makes it the world's great food wine."

SAUVIGNON BLANC

■ ■ Origin: Loire Valley, France

Synonyms: Fumé Blanc (California) · Blanc Fumé (Loire)

Electric acidity · The most instantly recognizable white

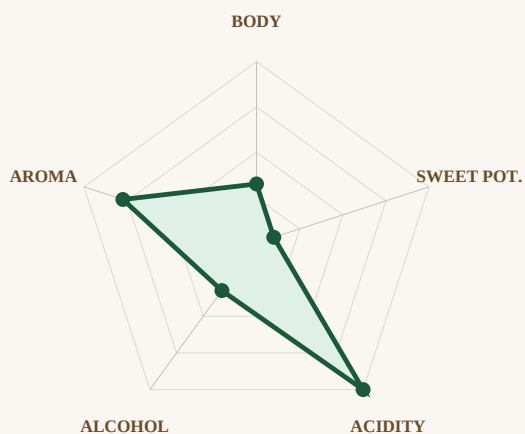


Pale Green-Yellow

Light Yellow

Vivid Yellow

Green Gold



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Light · lean
Sweet Potential	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Almost always bone dry
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Very high · electric
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Low · 11.5–13%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Loire Valley, France
Serve	8–10 °C · White wine glass
Aging	Most: 1–3y · Graves: 10–20y
Peak	1–5 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Parent of Cabernet Sauvignon (× Cab Franc)

ORIGIN & STORY

The grape that single-handedly put New Zealand on the international wine map when Cloudy Bay launched in 1985. The pyrazine compounds (identical to those in green bell pepper) create the characteristic grass and herb character — most intense in cool climates (Loire, Marlborough), almost absent in warm ones.

Didier Dagueneau's Silex and Pur Sang from Pouilly-Fumé redefined what Sauvignon Blanc could achieve — wines of extraordinary mineral complexity and longevity. When blended with Sémillon in Bordeaux, barrel-fermented and aged, it becomes something utterly different from its fresh, herbaceous self.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Sancerre · Pouilly-Fumé	Loire, France	Flint, mineral, citrus — the benchmark
■ ■ Marlborough	New Zealand	Passion fruit, grass, tropical — world-famous
■ ■ Graves · Pessac-Léognan	Bordeaux, France	Oaked, complex, age-worthy — a different world
■ ■ Constantia · Stellenbosch	South Africa	Tropical, fresh, excellent value
■ ■ Casablanca · Leyda	Chile	Coastal, crisp, citrus-driven
■ ■ Adelaide Hills · Margaret River	Australia	Cool-climate, elegant

SAUVIGNON BLANC

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



COOL CLIMATE

Grapefruit

Cut Grass

Gooseberry

Elderflower

Flint



TROPICAL

Passion Fruit

Lime

White Peach

Guava

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



OAKED / AGED

Smoked Flint

Smoke

Honey

Brioche

Lanolin

PALATE PROFILE

The most immediately recognizable white wine style. High acidity creates a wine that tastes electric and refreshing — it almost crackles on the palate. In cool climates, the pyrazine compounds (grass, herb) dominate; in warmer sites, tropical fruit takes over.

The finish is always clean and bright. When barrel-fermented and blended with Sémillon (as in the great Graves whites), it transforms into something of extraordinary complexity and longevity — one of the wine world's great revelations for those who know only the fresh Loire style.

SOIL AFFINITY

Limestone

Kimmeridgian Clay

Gravel

Sandy

Alluvial

Silex (flint)

PAIRS WELL WITH

Goat Cheese

Oysters

Asparagus

Salads

Shellfish

Sushi

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp

8–10 °C · White wine glass

Aging Window

Most: 1–3y · Graves: 10–20y

Peak Window

1–5 years

Decanting

No decanting

Famous Producers

Didier Dagueneau · Henri Bourgeois · Cloudy Bay · Greywacke · Haut-Brion Blanc

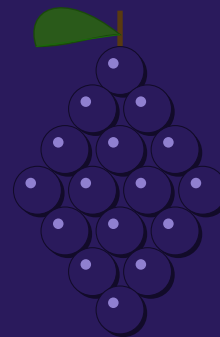
"Cloudy Bay's 1985 launch single-handedly put New Zealand on the international wine map — the power of one grape, one region, one moment."

SYRAH / SHIRAZ

■ ■ Origin: Northern Rhône, France

Synonyms: Syrah (cool climate) · Shiraz (Australia/warm) · Hermitage

One grape · two personalities · Cool vs warm defines everything

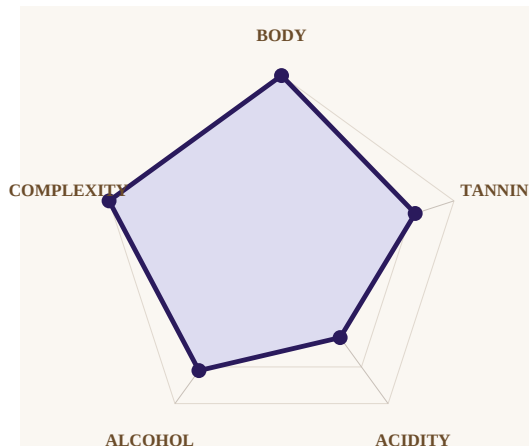


Deep Inky

Purple-Black

Dark Ruby

Very Dark



ATTRIBUTES

Body ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Very full · inky

Tannin ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ High · firm

Acidity ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Medium

Alcohol ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Medium-high · 13.5–15%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Northern Rhône, France
Serve	17–18 °C · Large Bordeaux glass
Aging	10–30+ years (Hermitage)
Peak	8–20 years
Decant	2 hrs young
Parentage	Native Rhône variety — confirmed by DNA 1999

ORIGIN & STORY

One grape, two completely different personalities separated by climate. The rotundone compound creates the characteristic black pepper aroma — highest in cool-climate Syrah from the Northern Rhône, nearly absent in warm-climate Barossa Shiraz. DNA analysis confirmed the grape is native to the Rhône Valley, debunking myths of Persian or Sicilian origin.

In cool Hermitage and Côte-Rôtie, the wine is tight, mineral, iron-tinged — savage when young, then unfolding over 20 years into something extraordinary. In warm Barossa: immediate, chocolate-generous, and built for pleasure. Penfolds Grange proved Shiraz could create wines that age for decades.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Hermitage · Côte-Rôtie · Cornas	Northern Rhône, France	Cool, mineral, iron, peppery — 20–40yr wines
■ ■ Barossa Valley · McLaren Vale	South Australia	Bold, jammy, chocolate — old vine intensity
■ ■ Santa Barbara County	California, USA	Cool coastal — Sta. Rita Hills Syrah rivals the Rhône
■ ■ Washington State	USA	Structured, mid-way between the two styles
■ ■ Swartland	South Africa	Old vine, natural wine — spicy, earthy, complex
■ ■ Yarra Valley	Victoria, Australia	Cool-climate, peppery, elegant Northern Rhône style

SYRAH / SHIRAZ

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:

 DARK FRUIT	<i>Blackberry</i>	<i>Dark Plum</i>	<i>Black Olive</i>	<i>Blueberry</i>
 SAVOURY	<i>Black Pepper</i>	<i>Smoked Meat</i>	<i>Iron</i>	<i>Olive</i>

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:

 AGED	<i>Leather</i>	<i>Violet</i>	<i>Licorice</i>	<i>Dark Chocolate</i>	<i>Bacon</i>
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PALATE PROFILE

The most dramatically climate-influenced grape. In cool Hermitage: tight, mineral, almost savage when young, revealing extraordinary complexity after 20 years. In warm Barossa: immediate, generous, chocolate and vanilla, built for pleasure. Tannins are firm in both styles but well-integrated in great examples.

The black pepper character (rotundone) is prominent in cool-climate versions — it appears on both nose and palate and is unmistakable. Warm-climate Shiraz replaces this with dark fruit richness, sometimes to the point of jamminess. The best examples from both climates can age magnificently.

SOIL AFFINITY

<i>Granite</i>	<i>Schist / Slate</i>	<i>Alluvial</i>	<i>Basalt</i>
<i>Sandy</i>	<i>Volcanic</i>		

PAIRS WELL WITH

<i>Lamb</i>	<i>Game</i>	<i>BBQ</i>	<i>Smoked Meats</i>
<i>Hard Aged Cheese</i>	<i>Steak</i>		

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp	17–18 °C · Large Bordeaux glass
Aging Window	10–30+ years (Hermitage)
Peak Window	8–20 years
Decanting	2 hrs young
Famous Producers	E. Guigal · Paul Jaboulet · Penfolds Grange · Two Hands · Torbreck · Sine Qua Non

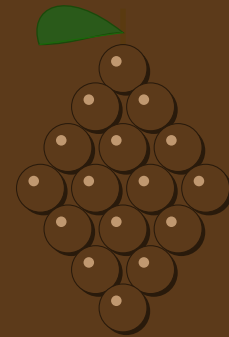
"Northern Rhône Syrah and Barossa Shiraz are the same grape — but they answer completely different questions about what wine can be."

TEMPRANILLO

■ ■ Origin: Rioja, Spain

Synonyms: Tinto Fino · Aragonez (Portugal) · Cencibel · Ull de Llebre · Tinta Roriz

Spain's flagship red · Oak-loving · Named 'little early one'

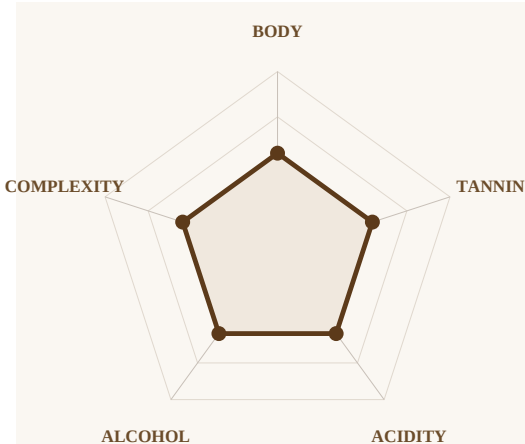


Ruby

Garnet

Warm Garnet

Brick Garnet



ATTRIBUTES

Body		Medium · balanced
Tannin		Medium · structured
Acidity		Medium · food-friendly
Alcohol		Medium · 13–14%

KEY FACTS

Type	Red wine grape
Origin	Rioja, Spain
Serve	17 °C · Bordeaux glass
Aging	Crianza: 3–5y · Gran Reserva: 10–25+y
Peak	8–20 years
Decant	1–2 hrs
Parentage	Ancient Spanish variety

ORIGIN & STORY

Spain's most important red grape, named 'little early one' (temprano = early) because it ripens earlier than other Spanish varieties. The Rioja aging classification — Crianza, Reserva, Gran Reserva — was built around Tempranillo's natural affinity for oak aging. Traditional American oak gives vanilla and coconut; modern French oak is subtler.

Vega Sicilia Único, aged for up to 12 years before release, is the grape's ultimate statement — one of Europe's most celebrated wines and among the longest-aging reds on the continent. In Ribera del Duero it produces darker, more powerful wines than Rioja.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Rioja Alta · Alavesa	La Rioja, Spain	The benchmark — Crianza through Gran Reserva
■ ■ Ribera del Duero	Castile, Spain	Darker, more powerful — Vega Sicilia country
■ ■ Navarra	Spain	More approachable, fresher expressions
■ ■ Alentejo (Aragonez)	Portugal	Warm, generous, food-friendly
■ ■ Douro (Tinta Roriz)	Portugal	Port blending partner — intense, structured

TEMPRANILLO

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



FRUIT

Dried Cherry

Dark Plum

Red Berry

Tomato



OAK

Vanilla

Dill (American oak)

Cedar

Coconut

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



AGED

Leather

Balsamic

Earth

Dried Herbs

Tobacco

PALATE PROFILE

Tempranillo's natural balance makes it immediately approachable but oak aging transforms it into something complex and structured. Moderate tannins, moderate acidity, moderate alcohol — a wine of balance that handles both young drinking and extended aging with equal grace.

The distinctive vanilla and dill character of American oak (still used in traditional Rioja) is its most recognizable international signature. Gran Reserva releases are often 10+ years old before they reach the shelf — the wine is already mature and ready to drink.

SOIL AFFINITY

Alluvial

Clay

Limestone

Clay-Limestone

Sandy

PAIRS WELL WITH

Lamb

Suckling Pig

Aged Manchego

Cured Ibérico

Veal

Steak

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp

17 °C · Bordeaux glass

Aging Window

Crianza: 3–5y · Gran Reserva: 10–25+y

Peak Window

8–20 years

Decanting

1–2 hrs

Famous Producers

Vega Sicilia · Pingus · La Rioja Alta · CVNE Imperial · Roda · Muga

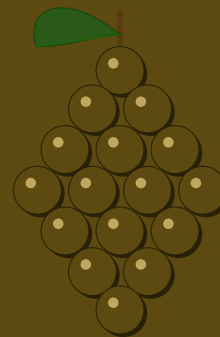
"The Rioja aging classification system — Crianza, Reserva, Gran Reserva — was built around Tempranillo's natural affinity for oak."

VIOGNIER

■ ■ Origin: Condrieu, Northern Rhône, France

Synonyms: Condrieu AOC · Château-Grillet · Co-fermented with Syrah in Côte-Rôtie

Nearly extinct in the 1960s · The most perfumed white · Drink young

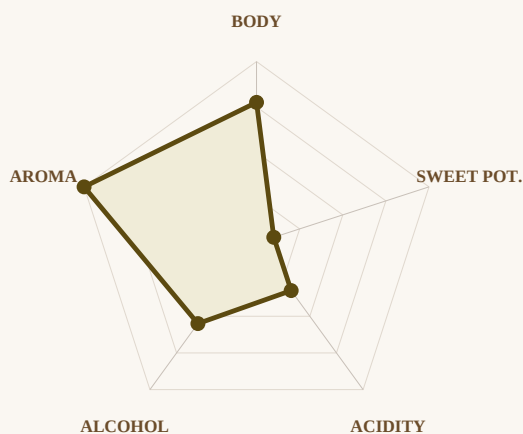


Pale Gold

Light Gold

Gold

Deep Gold



ATTRIBUTES

Body	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Full · generous
Sweet Potential	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Virtually always dry
Acidity	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Low · broad
Alcohol	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	Medium-high · 13.5–14.5%

KEY FACTS

Type	White wine grape
Origin	Condrieu, Northern Rhône, France
Serve	10–12 °C · White Burgundy glass
Aging	Most: 1–4y · Great Condrieu: up to 8y
Peak	2–5 years
Decant	No decanting
Parentage	Unknown — possibly native Rhône

ORIGIN & STORY

Nearly extinct in the 1960s — only 14 hectares of Condrieu remained. The wine world's intervention saved it, and today it is planted worldwide. The definitive version remains Condrieu: a tiny appellation producing wines of extraordinary floral intensity that justify their premium price.

Famously co-fermented with Syrah in the best Côte-Rôtie wines — adding aromatic perfume and colour stability. Low natural acidity means it must be harvested at precise ripeness — too early and it tastes bitter; too late and it becomes flabby. Most Vioigner should be drunk within 3–4 years.

KEY REGIONS WORLDWIDE

■ ■ Condrieu AOC	Northern Rhône, France	The definitive home — only ~160ha
■ ■ Château-Grillet	Northern Rhône	Single-estate monopole AOC — extremely rare
■ ■ Santa Barbara · Central Coast	California, USA	Rhône Rangers — rich, floral
■ ■ Virginia	USA	Growing reputation — aromatic, food-friendly
■ ■ Eden Valley	South Australia	Structured, complex — one of the best outside Rhône
■ ■ Languedoc	Southern France	Accessible, aromatic, value-driven

VIOGNIER

Aromas · Palate · Pairings · In The Cellar

AROMA PROFILE

PRIMARY — from the grape:



FRUIT

Apricot

White Peach

Mango

Tangerine



FLORAL

Honeysuckle

Jasmine

Orange Blossom

Acacia

TERTIARY — from aging in bottle:



RICH / AGED

Marzipan

Cream

White Pepper

Blossom Honey

PALATE PROFILE

Viognier's defining quality is its extraordinary aromatic generosity — the nose leaps from the glass with apricot, white blossom, and exotic fruit. Low acidity means the wine feels broad and rich on the palate — there is no sharpness, just texture and perfume.

This low acid also means it ages relatively quickly — most should be drunk within 3–4 years. Great Condrieu is one of the most hedonistic white wines in the world. The low acid can make it feel flabby in warm vintages — balance is critical and rare.

SOIL AFFINITY

Granite

Sandy

Schist / Slate

Decomposed Granite

Mixed

PAIRS WELL WITH

Lobster

Scallops

Foie Gras

Chicken

Aromatic Herb Dishes

Soft Cheese

IN THE CELLAR & AT THE TABLE

Serving Temp

10–12 °C · White Burgundy glass

Aging Window

Most: 1–4y · Great Condrieu: up to 8y

Peak Window

2–5 years

Decanting

No decanting

Famous Producers

Georges Vernay · Yves Cuilleron · E. Guigal (Condrieu) · Alban (CA) · Yalumba (AUS)

"Condrieu at its best is one of the most hedonistic white wines on earth — apricot, honeysuckle, and marzipan in a glass of extraordinary fragrance."